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May 23, 1945.

MEMORANDUM FOR THE PRESIDENT

In January of 1944, President Roosevelt established the War Refugee Board, consisting of the Secretary of State, the Secretary of the Treasury and the Secretary of War, for the purpose of taking all possible measures to rescue the persecuted peoples of Europe who were in imminent danger of death at the hands of the Nazis. With a small staff in Washington and representatives in strategic neutral countries, the War Refugee Board put the full prestige and power of the United States Government behind the efforts of private agencies and inter-governmental organizations, particularly the Inter-governmental Committee on Refugees and UNRRA. Although it is impossible to measure the success of the Board in terms of exact statistics, there is no doubt that many thousands of lives were saved as a result of its work. This was accomplished because the problem was recognized and dealt with as one requiring attention by the government at the highest level.

The great humanitarian task assigned to the War Refugee Board is now practically completed. There is left, however, the equally great problem of the resettlement of hundreds of thousands of displaced persons who are unable or unwilling to return to their homelands. The Inter-governmental Committee on Refugees was authorized to arrange for the rehabilitation and resettlement of such displaced persons. However, if the Inter-governmental Committee is to do a successful job, the full force and weight of the United States Government must be placed behind its resettlement activities as was done in the case of its rescue activities.

Since the device of a Cabinet Committee has been so successful in the case of the War Refugee Board, it is my view that every consideration should be given to continuing this device with respect to the problems of the homeless victims of Nazi oppression, whose lives have been saved in large measure as the result of the activities of this Government.